WHITE PAPER · MARCH 2026

The Fan Intelligence Gap

Why Your Merchandise Is Your Most Undervalued Data Asset

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Contents

Overview	Executive Summary	3
Section 01	The Problem: A $36 Billion Black Box	4
Section 02	The Data Gap: What You Know vs. What You Should Know	5
Section 03	The Merchandise Opportunity: Physical Items as Data Channels	6
Section 04	The Framework: From Transaction to Intelligence	7
Section 05	The Market Is Moving — Fast	8
Section 06	The College Athletics Urgency	9
Section 07	Getting Started: The 90-Day Path	10
Conclusion	The Bottom Line	11
Appendix	Sources & References	12

OVERVIEW

Executive Summary

Sports organizations sit on a $36 billion merchandise market — and get almost nothing from it except revenue. Every jersey sold, every giveaway handed out, every hat worn to a tailgate represents a fan interaction that generates zero data. Meanwhile, sponsors are demanding proof that their partnerships actually work, and 76% of them can't calculate their ROI.

The industry has a fan intelligence problem. Not a fan *engagement* problem — an *intelligence* problem. Teams know how many people walked through the gate. They don't know who those people are, what they care about, or how they behave after the final whistle.

This paper lays out the case for why merchandise — the physical products fans already buy, wear, and take home — is the most overlooked first-party data channel in sports. We'll walk through the market forces making this urgent, the data gap costing teams millions in sponsor value, and a framework for turning every piece of team gear into a persistent fan identity asset.

$36B
Licensed sports merch market generating almost zero fan intelligence

76%
Of sponsors who cannot accurately calculate their ROI (Forrester)

94%
Of smartphones worldwide are NFC-equipped (ElectroIQ)

0.5%
Industry average digital display ad CTR — vs. 15–40% NFC engagement

SECTION 01

The Problem: A $36 Billion Black Box

The global licensed sports merchandise market is valued at $35.7–36.4 billion (Straits Research, Grand View Research, Expert Market Research — 2024 estimates). North America accounts for over 52% of that revenue.

That's the number everyone knows. Here's the number nobody talks about: how much fan intelligence does that $36 billion generate? Almost none.

A fan buys a jersey. The transaction is recorded. But what happens after that? They wear it to 15 games, to a watch party in another city, to the gym on a Tuesday. Each of those moments represents intent, location, loyalty — and the team captures none of it.

Why This Matters Now

FORCE 01 — SPONSORS WANT PROOF

76% of sponsors cannot accurately calculate their ROI (Forrester). The global sports sponsorship market is $60–65B and projected to nearly double by 2033. Teams that can't deliver data-driven accountability will lose deals to teams that can.

FORCE 02 — FIRST-PARTY DATA IS NO LONGER OPTIONAL

Deloitte identified "investments in fan data" as one of five major 2024 industry trends. The NFL has 250+ attributes per fan profile. FC Bayern Munich integrated 50+ data systems. The question for everyone else: what's your plan?

FORCE 03 — THE COOKIE IS DYING

Nearly 90% of marketers are shifting toward first- and zero-party data. Chrome holds 66.8% of global browser usage. When third-party cookies go away, so does cheap targeting. The teams that own first-party fan data become the targeting layer.

SECTION 02

The Data Gap: What You Know vs. What You Should Know

Most sports organizations are stuck at Stage 1 or Stage 2 of fan data maturity — collecting and measuring basic metrics — but can't predict or personalize (FanCompass, Jan 2026). Here's what that looks like in practice:

✓ WHAT TEAMS TYPICALLY KNOW	✗ WHAT TEAMS DON'T KNOW
Ticket sales (who bought, what section, how much)	Who's wearing their merch outside the stadium
Season ticket holder info and renewal history	Which fans engage with sponsor activations beyond impressions
Concession revenue (aggregate, not per-fan)	Whether a giveaway item generated any post-event interaction
App downloads and basic digital engagement	The identity of 40,000+ fans wearing branded gear on game day
Social media follower counts	How fan engagement changes across seasons and life stages

> *"Fan data is becoming not just an integral part of sponsorship agreements, but may be the primary thing brands want. Not having robust fan data could deter top sponsors and partners."*
>
> — DELOITTE, 2025 SPORTS INDUSTRY OUTLOOK

According to BCG's "Beyond Media Rights" report (Feb 2026), top NFL teams generate roughly 2x the sponsorship revenue of bottom teams. In the Premier League, the gap is 7–8x. Their recommendation: teams need unified fan identity, experience platforms, and commercial data structures.

SECTION 03

The Merchandise Opportunity: Physical Items as Data Channels

You already have a massive first-party data collection network. It's called your merchandise program. Every jersey, every giveaway, every premium item you put into a fan's hands is a physical touchpoint. Right now, those touchpoints are one-way — team to fan, end of story. But they don't have to be.

NFC (Near Field Communication) technology makes it possible to turn any physical product into a two-way data channel. Embed a chip. Fan taps their phone. Content loads in their browser — no app required. Every tap generates a data point: who, where, when, what device, what they engaged with. NTAG 424 DNA chips provide AES-128 encryption and require no battery. They're powered by the phone's NFC field. Waterproof. 94% of smartphones worldwide are NFC-equipped (ElectroIQ).

Why NFC Over Other Methods

Metric	Mobile Apps	QR Codes	NFC (Vonga)
Engagement Rate	**3–5%**	**~3%**	**15–40%**
Friction	Download required	Camera + steady hand	Phone near chip. Done.
Fan Identity	Login required	None (anonymous)	Progressive profile builds automatically
Works on jersey?	❌ App-dependent	❌ Fails in low light / distance	✅ Always
Persistent data?	⚠️ Only while app active	❌ One-time scan	✅ Every tap enriches profile

SECTION 04

The Framework: From Transaction to Intelligence

Turning merchandise into a data channel isn't about chips. It's about building a system that converts physical fan interactions into usable intelligence. Here's the framework:

1. **Identity**

   Every NFC tap captures device signature, location, timestamp, and behavior. After multiple taps across items and events, you build a progressive fan profile — not from form fills, but from actual behavior. Each tap makes the picture richer.

2. **Segmentation**

   Not demographic buckets (male, 25–34, zip code) but behavioral segments: fans who engage on game day vs. all week. Fans who tap in-venue vs. remotely. High-frequency tappers vs. one-and-done. This is the difference between knowing fans by headcount and knowing them by name.

3. **Sponsor Proof**

   Not estimated impressions. Not logo placement hours. Verified fan interactions with sponsor-branded content, traceable to individual fans, with engagement rates and behavioral data attached. Pulselive: "Sports organisations must provide demonstrable proof of ROI." NFC-powered merch provides that at the individual fan level.

4. **Persistence**

   Unlike a stadium visit or app notification, merchandise goes home with the fan. A jersey isn't a one-night engagement channel — it's a 3-year data asset. Every time a fan taps, you learn something new. The relationship compounds.

SECTION 05

The Market Is Moving — Fast

This isn't a theoretical future. Major organizations are already investing heavily in fan data infrastructure:

- **The NFL** built a data ecosystem with 250+ attributes per fan profile (Deloitte).
- **FC Bayern Munich** integrated 50+ data systems into a unified "Golden Fan Record" (Deloitte).
- **MLB** partnered with Adobe's Real-Time CDP across all 30 clubs. Their VP of digital: *"We've started thinking about our data as something that can enhance some of the broader partnerships that we have at the league level."*
- **The IOC** deployed a Fan Data Platform for Paris 2024, generating 12 billion+ engagements and ~300 million digital users.
- **Sportradar** launched FanID — a first-party marketing solution explicitly to solve "connecting rightsholders and brands with sports fans in a post-cookie world."
- **Manchester City × PUMA × EA Sports** shipped NFC-enabled jerseys at Premier League scale — fans tap the crest to unlock in-game content.

250+
Fan profile attributes in the NFL's data ecosystem

50+
Data systems integrated by FC Bayern Munich

7–8×
Sponsorship revenue gap, top vs bottom Premier League clubs

> *"Teams need unified fan identity, experience platforms, and commercial data structures."*
>
> — BCG, "BEYOND MEDIA RIGHTS," FEBRUARY 2026

SECTION 06

The College Athletics Urgency

If you're in college athletics, the pressure is even more acute.

> *"We have to realize there is donor fatigue. There is NIL-donor fatigue, ticket prices fatigue from our customers. We can't just keep going up, going up and asking donors for this and that. We're straining the whole system. This system we're sitting in today is not sustainable. Not at all."*
>
> — VERGE AUSBERRY, LSU ATHLETIC DIRECTOR, FEBRUARY 2026

If a blue-blood program with LSU's resources is calling the model unsustainable, every mid-major is feeling it 10x worse.

The traditional college athletics revenue model — ticket sales, donations, conference distributions — is under structural pressure. NIL has introduced new competition for donor dollars. Conference realignment is reshuffling media revenue. And athletics departments are being asked to do more with the same (or fewer) resources.

Fan data represents a new revenue layer — not replacing existing streams, but augmenting them. When you can prove to a sponsor exactly how many fans engaged with their activation, at what frequency, and with what behavioral patterns, you're not selling impressions. You're selling intelligence. That commands a premium.

And the fan data you collect doesn't expire when a student graduates. A chip in a jersey works for years. The fan profile persists. The relationship continues.

SECTION 07

Getting Started: The 90-Day Path

The transition from merchandise-as-product to merchandise-as-data-channel doesn't require a platform overhaul or a two-year implementation timeline.

01

DAYS 1–30

Pilot Design & Procurement

Select one product category. Define the fan experience. Order NFC tags. Brief your merch supplier on the embedding process.

02

DAYS 31–60

Integration & Embedding

Tags arrive pre-encoded. Supplier embeds into products. Platform configured with your branding, content, and sponsors. Test taps verify end-to-end.

03

DAYS 61–90

Live Data

Items reach fans. Taps generate data. Fan profiles build progressively. Sponsor dashboards populate with verified engagement metrics.

The pilot proves or disproves the model with your fans, your merch, your sponsors. No multi-year commitment required.

CONCLUSION

The Bottom Line

The sports industry is sitting on a $36 billion merchandise market that generates almost no fan intelligence. Sponsors are demanding data-driven accountability. First-party data is becoming the primary thing brands want from partnerships. And the teams that build fan data infrastructure now will have a structural advantage over those that don't.

Every jersey, every giveaway, every premium item is an opportunity to learn something about the fan holding it. Right now, that opportunity is wasted.

It doesn't have to be.

Ready to see what fan intelligence looks like for your program?

Schedule a 20-minute walkthrough at **calendly.com/bill-vonga/30min** or email **bill@vonga.io**

APPENDIX

Sources & References

Deloitte, "2024 Sports Industry Outlook" and "2025 Sports Industry Outlook"

PwC, "Global Sports Survey 2024" and Sports Sponsorship Playbook

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Marketing Dive — MLB + Adobe Real-Time CDP partnership (2025)

ElectroIQ — NFC Payment Statistics (2025)

Sportradar — FanID Launch announcement (January 2024)

StatCounter — Global Browser Market Share (May 2025)

Adtelligent — Privacy and Data Landscape Report (2025)

FanCompass — Fan Data Maturity Curve (January 2026)

Pulselive — Fan Engagement and Sponsorship ROI (2024)

Mobilo Card — NFC vs QR Code Comparison Study (2025)

Verge Ausberry, LSU Athletic Director — Public remarks, February 2026

Ready to turn your merchandise into a fan intelligence platform?

We'll show you exactly what fan intelligence looks like for your program — and what that data is worth to your sponsors.

Schedule a 20-Minute Walkthrough

bill@vonga.io · vonga.io